

Chapter 1

A quantifier-particle approach to exclusive focus particles in Yorùbá

Ka-Fai Yip

Yale University

Olabode Adedeji

Yale University

This paper motivates a novel quantifier-particle approach to exclusive doubling. Yorùbá has two exclusive focus particles ‘only’: preverbal *kàn* and adfocal *nikan*, which may be doubled with a single focus association and result in an apparent form-meaning mismatch. It is argued that *nikan* is the exclusive quantifier while *kàn* is a scope-marking particle indicating the (c)overt movement of *nikan* with the focus. Arguments are presented against the operator-particle approach proposed for other languages, based on the distinct association and scopal behavior in Yorùbá. It is shown that despite surface similarities, there are cross-linguistic variations in exclusive focus particles and doubling.

1 Introduction

Exclusive focus particles like *only* in English are known to have variable positions (Horn 1969; Jackendoff 1972; Taglicht 1984; Rooth 1985; Büring & Hartmann 2001, *i.a.*). In (1a)-(1b), for example, *only* may be used adverbially in a preverbal position, or adfocally to the left of the focus. These two uses of *only*, however, generally cannot co-occur in the same clause with a single focus association (AwF), as shown in (1c).

- (1) a. John **only** gave MARY_F a book. (adverbial/sentential *only*)
 b. John gave **only** MARY_F a book. (adfocal/adnominal/constituent *only*)
 c. *John **only** gave **only** MARY_F a book (doubling prohibited)
 Int.: ‘The only one that John gave a book to was Mary.’

In Yorùbá (Benue-Congo), the adverbial-adfocal distinction is manifested as two exclusive focus particles with different forms: preverbal *kàn* and adfocal *nikan*, as exemplified in (2a) and (2b) respectively. They are largely understudied and only noted in passing in Bisang & Sonaiya (2000: 190).¹ Notably, we observe that the two particles, unlike English, may co-occur in the same clause with a single AwF, as in (2c). The truth condition remains the same as (2a)-(2b), which constitutes a case of *form-meaning mismatch*: apparently only one particle is interpreted as the exclusive. We refer to these cases as *exclusive doubling*.²

- (2) a. Ayò **kàn** fún Adé_F ní iwé. (preverbal particle)
 John only give Mary SEC book
 ‘Ayo only gave Ade a book.’
 b. Ayò fún Adé_F **nikan** ní iwé. (adfocal particle)
 Ayo give Ade only SEC book
 ‘Ayo gave only Ade a book.’
 c. Ayò **kàn** fún Adé_F **nikan** ní iwé. (exclusive doubling)
 Ayo only give Ade only SEC book
 ‘Ayo only gave Ade a book.’ (truth condition=a/b)

Exclusive doubling (also called “only”-concord) has been attested cross-linguistically, such as in Cantonese (Yip 2024; 2025), Dutch (Barbiers 2010; Hole 2015), German (Hole 2015; Bayer 2020), Kasem (Mabia, Gur; Aremu 2025), Korean (Lee 2005), Mandarin (Hole 2017; Sun 2021; Yip 2025) and Vietnamese (Hole 2017; Erlewine 2017; Quek & Hirsch 2017; Sun 2021; Yip 2025). One prominent view on resolving the form-meaning mismatch is the *operator-particle approach* (henceforth OP-approach), which posits that the adverbial/preverbal ‘only’ is an

¹Recently, Aremu (2026) follows up on our work and provides more description of the properties of these two particles.

²*Ní* (high tone, ≠ mid-tone focus marker *ní*) here is a marker to introduce the theme *iwé* ‘book’. It may also be used to introduce a locative (e.g., *ita* ‘outside’) or a time (e.g., *òla* ‘tomorrow’). It has been glossed differently in literature as LOC, CM (case marker), etc. We follow Atoyebi et al. (2011) and gloss it as a “secundative preposition”.

exclusive operator, and the adfocal ‘only’ is a “concord” particle which establishes a syntactic relation with the operator (Bayer 1996; Lee 2005; Quek & Hirsch 2017; Bassi et al. 2022; Hirsch 2022; Sun 2021; Branan & Erlewine 2023; Yip 2025; Aremu 2025, *i.a.*). The particle is claimed to be semantically inert.³ Thus, there is no real “mismatch”—there is only one operator. An illustration is given below:

- (3) [OP_{EXCL}/only_{adverbial} ... [Prt_{EXCL}/only_{adfocal} [XP_F]]

The goal of this paper is two-fold. First, it provides a detailed description of the syntactic and semantic properties of *kàn* and *nikan*, filling in the empirical gap on Yorùbá focus. Second, it argues for an alternative and novel approach to exclusive doubling, namely, the **quantifier-particle approach** (henceforth Q-approach). Under the Q-approach, it is the adfocal particle but not the preverbal particle that carries the exclusive semantics. Drawing crucial evidence from AwF and scopal behavior of ‘only’, we show that adfocal *nikan* is an exclusive quantifier, and the preverbal *kàn* is merely a scope-marking particle but not an operator. These two particles are related by syntactic movement, which may be covert or overt:

- (4) [Prt_{EXCL}/only_{preverbal} ... [Qu_{EXCL}/only_{adfocal} [XP_F]]]

We also present a set of diagnostics to distinguish between the Q-approach and the OP-approach concerning their empirical predictions. This paper contributes to the ongoing debate on whether ‘only’ is a one-place propositional operator or a two-place quantifier (Rooth 1985; 1992; Erlewine 2017; Quek & Hirsch 2017; Bassi et al. 2022) by demonstrating that languages vary in the semantics of exclusive focus particles.

This paper is organized as follows. §2 compares the AwF properties of preverbal *kàn* and adfocal *nikan*. §3 contrasts the scopal behavior of the two particles and its locality constraints. §4 motivates the Q-approach with the Yorùbá data, and presents four arguments against the OP-approach. §5 concludes the paper with an outlook of cross-linguistic variations in exclusive focus particles.

Before proceeding, two notes are in order. First, while both *kàn* and *nikan* have quantificational/non-scalar exclusive readings, *kàn* additionally has a scalar

³Although Hole (2017); Yip (2024) observe that the particle may carry a scalar meaning, it still does not carry an exclusive semantics. We have also observed the effect of scalarity for *kàn* (see the end of this section).

reading, as in (5). Here, *nikan* expresses an infelicitous reading where John could have got two kinds of points (e.g., one for performance and one for participation). To express the scalar reading that John's point is lower than some alternative (e.g., Mary's point), only *kàn*, as well as a scalar adfocal particle *lásán* 'only, just' (which is not reported in Bisang & Sonaiya 2000), may be used. Another scalar particle *péré* 'only, just', discussed recently by Aremu (2026), can also be used here. We will focus on the quantificational reading throughout this paper.⁴

- (5) Ìdà ọgọrin {#*nikan*/ *lásán*/ *péré*} ni John *kàn* gbà nínú èkò
 present eighty only just just FOC John only get inside course
 Faranse.
 French
 'John only got 80 points for French.' (while Mary got 90 points!)

Second, the data in this paper is based on the Standard Yorùbá variety. The sentences and judgments were collected and confirmed in elicitation sessions with three native speakers, as well as constructed by the second author who is also a native speaker of Yorùbá.

2 Association with focus of exclusive particles

2.1 Adfocal *nikan*

Let us discuss association with focus of the adfocal particle *nikan* first. Its syntactic position depends on the position of the focus associate. *Nikan* attaches to the right of an in-situ focus, as shown in (6).⁵ Association at a distance is not possible. *Nikan* may attach to any argument in a clause, or even a VP, but not to a verb. When *nikan* is at the clause-final position, AwF is ambiguous between the VP and the last argument (i.e., the direct object in (6d)).

⁴*Kàn* also allows for a non-exclusive downplaying reading, which we set aside in this paper.

- (i) [Akin *kàn* ẹ German] ni. (ó tún ẹ Faransé.)
 Akin just do German FOC 3SG also do French
 'John just took German (as a requirement, nothing special). He also took French.'

⁵This is different from English adfocal *only* which attaches to the left of the focus. We do not discuss the difference further, but see Carstens & Zeller (2020) for a discussion on phrase-final exclusive particles.

- (6) a. Ayọ̀ **nìkan** fún Ade ní iwé. (Subj focus)
 Ayo only give Ade SEC book
 ‘Only Ayo (but not Akin) gave Ade a book.’
- b. *Ayò fún **nìkan** Ade ní iwé. (*Verb focus)
 Ayo give only Ade SEC book
 Int.: ‘Ayo only gave Ade a book (but not sold).’
- c. Ayò fún Ade **nìkan** ní iwé. (IO focus)
 Ayo give Ade only SEC book
 ‘Ayo gave only Ade (but not Olu) a book.’
- d. Ayò [fún Ade [ní iwé]_{i. F}]_{ii. F} **nìkan**. (DO/VP focus)
 Ayo give Ade SEC book only
 i. ‘Ayo gave Ade only a book (but not a drawing).’ or
 ii. ‘Ayo only gave Ade a book (but not sold Olu a drawing).’

Moreover, *nìkan* may associate with a DP-internal focus, as in (7), where (i)-(ii) represent association with the head noun *iwé* ‘book’ and the modifier *Faransé* ‘French’ respectively. Reading (i) is an exceptional case where *nìkan* is not adjacent to the focus, which we take to be a last resort strategy since *nìkan* cannot appear within a DP, as in (8).

- (7) Adé fẹ̀ràn [iwé_{i. F} Faransé_{ii. F}]_{iii. F} **nìkan**.
 Ade like book French only
 Lit.: ‘Ade likes only French books.’
- i. (Q: Does Ade like French drawings? A: No, ...) ‘Ade only likes French books.’ (He actually likes books of any language.)
- ii. (Q: Does Ade like drawings and books? A: Ade likes drawings, but ...) ‘Ade only like French books.’ (He doesn’t like non-French books.)
- iii. (Q: What does Ade like? A: ...) ‘Ade likes French books.’ (He likes nothing else.)
- (8) *Adé fẹ̀ràn [iwé **nìkan** Faransé].
 Ade like book only French
 Int.: ‘Ade likes only French books.’

When the focus is ex-situ, *nìkan* moves along to the clause initial position, followed by the focus marker *ni* (Awóbùlúyì 1978; Bisang & Sonaiya 2000; Aremu

2024), as in (9).⁶

- (9) Ex-situ object focus (with *nikan*)
- a. Akin *şe* German_F **nikan** (*ni) lẹ̀ẹ̀mejì. (in-situ)
Akin do German only FOC twice
'Akin only took *German* twice.'
 - b. German_F **nikan** ni Akin *şe* __ lẹ̀ẹ̀mejì. (movement)
German only FOC Akin do twice
'It is only *German* that Akin took twice.'

Note that *nikan* may also associate with clauses with focus movement, including the complement clause in (10a) and the adjunct/adverbial clause in (10b).⁷ For simplicity, we focus on the nominal cases throughout the paper.

- (10) a. [pé ó fẹ̀ràn Adé]_F **nikan** ni John sọ.
that 3SG love Ade only FOC John say
'The only thing John said is that he loves Ade.' (complement CP)
- b. [Tí John bá jẹ ọ̀gèdẹ̀]_F **nikan** ni ikùn máa dùn ún.
when John if eat banana only FOC stomach will pain 3SG
'Only when John eats a banana, his tummy will feel bad.' (adv. CP)

We also briefly discuss the interaction of adjuncts and focus movement below. As observed by Carstens (1987), extraction of adjuncts requires spelling out *ti*, *fi*, or *şe* in the preverbal field, as illustrated in (11) with locative PP adjuncts.⁸

⁶Acute readers may have realized that the two syllables in *nikan*, *ni* (low tone) and *kan* (mid-tone), seem to be related to the focus marker *ni* (mid-tone) and the preverbal exclusive particle *kàn* (low tone), although the tones are different. If one also considers the morpheme *kan* (mid-tone) 'one' and how English *only* is developed from Old English *anlic*, consisting of *an* 'one' and *lic* 'like' (later developed to *-ly*) (Onions 1966), it is tempting to claim that *kan* developed into both *kàn* and *nikan* with an extra low tone docking to the first syllable. Unfortunately, there are no sufficient historical resources of early Yorùbá for us to track the etymology of both focus particles. We however take this to be indirect evidence that they establish a grammatical dependency, as we will argue for in this paper. We thank an anonymous reviewer for drawing our attention to this point.

⁷(10a) has an alternative reading: 'John said that the only one John loves is Ade', where the associate is the embedded object 'Ade' and the whole CP is pied-piped with the focus.

⁸Carstens (1987) treats these three morphemes as expletives serving to "identify the head of the chain containing the adjunct trace" (p.69), as a surrogate strategy of antecedent government. As we will see in (14b), *ti* expresses perfective aspect. Independently, *fi* means 'use' and *şe* mean 'do' (which can also be a light verb). While we do not present a formal analysis of why they

The same patterns are observed for manner and reason adjuncts (but not for time adjuncts).

- (11) a. Àlàké (ti) ṣéré ní ìta. (in-situ)
 Alake PFV play at outside
 ‘Alake played outside’
 b. Níbo ni Àlàké *(ti) ṣéré __. (wh-movement)
 where FOC Alake PFV play
 ‘Where did Alake play?’
 (Adapted from Carstens 1987:62-63, progressive *ní* removed)

Turning to *nìkan*, it may associate with nominals within a PP adjunct, as in (12). Interestingly, *ti* is required once the adjunct undergoes focus movement. Note that the preposition *ní* is absent after movement: it cannot be pied-piped, nor can it be stranded.

- (12) Locative adjunct focus
 a. Àlàké (ti) ṣéré ní ìta_F nìkan. (in-situ)
 Alake PFV play at outside only
 ‘Alake only played outside.’
 b. Ìta_F nìkan ni Àlàké *(ti) ṣéré __. (focus movement)
 outside only FOC Alake PFV play
 ‘It was only outside that Alake played.’

2.2 Preverbal *kàn*

Now we turn to the preverbal particle *kàn*. First, it has a fixed syntactic position. As shown in (13), it may only occur between the subject and verb.

- (13) {*kàn} Ayò {kàn} fún {*kàn} Adé_F {*kàn} ní iwé {*kàn}.
 only John only give only Mary only SEC book only
 ‘Ayo only gave Ade a book.’

(14a) gives the general clausal schema in Yorùbá, where only particles may occur between the subject and the verb. Adjuncts can only occur in clause-initial

are required with adjunct extraction, we believe that they mark the boundary of the clausal-internal phase whose edge hosts intermediate movement. We wish to explore this topic in future work.

or clause-final positions. In the preverbal field, the particles also have a fixed word order, as summarized in (14b).

- (14) a. The general clausal schema in Yorùbá
Adjunct — Topic/Focus — COMP — S — **Particles** — V — O — Adjunct
- b. The preverbal field in Yorùbá
S — NEG — Q/ONLY — MUST — HAB/PFV — MAY/PROG — V
S — *kò/kiì* — *ha/kàn* — *gbọdọ* — *máa/ti* — *lè/ń* — V

The examples in (15) show that *kàn* occurs after the negation, but before other particles including modal and aspectual particles. It occupies the same slot as the question particle *ha* and cannot co-occur with it.

- (15) a. Adé {*kò/kiì*} **kàn** {**kò/kiì*} jẹ̀ ìrẹ̀sì (NEG>*kàn*, **kàn*>NEG)
Ade NEG/NEG.HAB only NEG/NEG.HAB eat rice
'Ade didn't only eat rice/Ade doesn't only eat rice.'
- b. *Sẹ̀ Adé {*ha*} **kàn** {*ha*} ka ìwé kan nìkan? (*Q>*kàn*, **kàn*>Q)
Q Ade Q only Q read book one only
Int.: 'Does Ade only read one book?'
- c. Adé {**gbọdọ*} **kàn** {*gbọdọ*} jẹ̀ ìrẹ̀sì (*MUST>*kàn*, *kàn*>MUST)
Ade must only must eat rice
'Ade only must eat rice.' (only rice is compulsory; meat is optional)
NOT: 'Ade must only eat rice.' (meat is prohibited)
- d. Adé {**ti*} **kàn** {*ti*} ka ìwé kan (*PFV>*kàn*, *kàn*>PFV)
Ade PFV only PFV read book one
'Ade has only read one book.'
- e. Adé {**ń*} **kàn** {*ń*} ka ìwé (*PROG>*kàn*, *kàn*>PROG)
Ade PROG only PROG read book one
'Ade is only reading books.'

Unlike *nìkan*, the AwF of *kàn* may be at a distance. Consider (16):

- (16) Ayọ̀ **kàn** [fún_{i. F} Adé_{ii. F} [ní ìwé]_{iii. F}]_{iv. F} (V/IO/DO/VP focus)
Ayo only give Ade SEC book
- i. 'Ayo only gave (but not sell) Ade a book.' or
ii. 'Ayo only gave Ade (but not Olu) a book.' or
iii. 'Ayo only gave Ade a book (but not a drawing).' or
iv. 'Ayo only gave Ade a book (but not selling Olu a drawing).'

Kàn may associate with any element under its c-command domain, such as the verb, direct and indirect objects, and VP, but not the subject which is outside its c-command domain. The initial pattern is similar to English adverbial *only*.

If we turn to ex-situ cases, however, Yorùbá differs from English in allowing backward AwF. In (17b), the focused object undergoes *ni*-movement to a position before *kàn*. Nevertheless, the truth condition remains the same as the in-situ case in (17a). That is, *kàn* associates backward with the moved object.⁹ Exclusive doubling with *nikan* is also possible in (17c). Such patterns are not allowed in English (Tancredi 1990; Erlewine 2014, *i.a.*), as illustrated in (18).

(17) Ex-situ object focus

- a. Akín *kàn* *şe* German_F. (in-situ, obj focus)
Akin only do German
'Akin only took German.'
- b. German_F *ni* Akín *kàn* *şe* __. (movement, obj focus)
German FOC John only do
'It is only German that Akin took.' (truth condition=a/c)
- c. German_F *nikan* *ni* Akín *kàn* *şe* __. (movement, obj focus)
German only FOC John only do
'It is only German that Akin took.' (truth condition=a/b)

(18) We are discussing what language courses John took. You say:

- a. John only took GERMAN_F.
- b. #It is GERMAN_F that John only took. (truth condition≠a/c)
- c. #It is only GERMAN_F that John only took. (truth condition≠a/b)

The subject focus case is even more notable. While *kàn* cannot associate with the in-situ subject, AwF becomes possible once the subject undergoes *ni*-focus movement, as in (19).¹⁰

⁹Backward AwF without *nikan* (i.e., (17b)) is marked in some dialects, but nevertheless acceptable and can be heard frequently in Standard Yorùbá.

¹⁰That subjects but not objects must be moved for *kàn*'s association is reminiscent of Zimmermann (2006); Fiedler et al. (2010)'s findings that explicit focus marking is usually required for subjects but not objects, the latter being in the default focus VP domain. This subject-object asymmetry is also found in Yorùbá in answers to *wh*-questions. According to Zimmermann (2006), subjects may receive default topichood and thus require explicit marking when focused. Interestingly, as we will see in the next section, no overt focus marking on embedded subjects

(19) Ex-situ subject focus

- a. Akín_(*F) **kàn** wá_F (in-situ, only V focus)
 Akin only come
 ‘Akin only/just came (and did nothing else).’
- b. Akín_F (**nìkan**) ni ó **kàn** wá (movement, subj focus)
 Akin only FOC 3SG only come
 ‘It is only *Akin* that came.’ (truth condition ≠ a)

Next, we turn to the scopal differences between *kàn* and *nìkan*.

3 Scopal behavior of exclusive particles

3.1 Wide scope interpretation

English adfocal *only* is long known for its scopal ambiguities (Taglicht 1984; Rooth 1985, i.a.). In (20), *only* is embedded in the complement clause taken by the attitude verb *know*, and may either take narrow scope under it (=a) or wide scope over it (=b). The same ambiguities do not arise with adverbial *only*.

- (20) I knew [(that) he had learnt only SPANISH_F]. (Taglicht 1984:150)
- a. *Narrow scope (knew>only)*: I knew that he had only learnt *Spanish*, i.e., hadn’t learnt any other language
- b. *Wide scope (only>knew)*: I only knew that he had learnt *Spanish*, i.e., didn’t know about any other language

In Yorùbá, *nìkan* also displays scopal ambiguities. (21b) has both narrow scope and wide scope readings, the former of which is infelicitous given the preceding sentence in (21a) (i.e., if the teacher knows that John only took German, s/he also knows that John didn’t take French). The wide scope reading across the embedded CP boundary is the only felicitous reading.¹¹

is required with *kàn* in the matrix clause. This can be explained if only embedded subjects do not carry default topichood. We thank an anonymous reviewer for drawing our attention to the subject-object asymmetry.

¹¹Some may ask whether *nìkan* in (21b) is really attached to the embedded object or it may be in the matrix level, given the possible structural ambiguities. This can be clarified by the example below, where *nìkan* is followed by the frequency phrase *lẹ́ẹ̀mejì* ‘twice’ that is interpreted in the embedded clause, but *nìkan* is still able to take wide scope.

(21) Wide scope across CPs (object focus)

- a. Olùkó kò mò [bóyá John ɕe Faransé], ...
teacher NEG know whether John do French, ...
‘The teacher doesn’t know whether John took French or not, ...’
- b. ... Olùkó mò [pé John ɕe German_F nìkan].
teacher know COMP John do German only
- i. ‘#The teacher knows that John only took *German*.’ (know>only)
ii. ‘The teacher only knows that John took *German*.’ (only>know)

Kàn, on the other hand, does not have such ambiguities, and indeed disambiguates the two readings in exclusive doubling. In (22a), *nìkan* can only take narrow scope with the embedded *kàn*. When *kàn* is in the matrix clause above *mò* ‘know’ in (22b), *nìkan* can only take wide scope.

- (22) a. ... # Olùkó mò [pé John kàn ɕe German_F nìkan].
teacher know COMP John only do German only
ONLY: ‘#The teacher knows that John only took *German*.’ (know>only)
- b. ... Olùkó kàn mò [pé John ɕe German_F nìkan].
teacher only know COMP John do German only
ONLY: ‘The teacher only knows that John took *German*.’ (only>know)

We further provide an example of wide scope with subject focus in (23). Note that either *kàn* or *nìkan* can be omitted.

(23) Wide scope across CPs (subject focus)

There are five students in the class. The teacher asked other students to report whether they took French. Only Ade reported to the teacher. So, ...

- a. Olùkó kàn mò [pé Adé_F (nìkan) ɕe Faransé]. (... (c))
teacher only know COMP Ade only do French
‘The teacher only know that *Ade* took French.’ (only > know)

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- (i) Olùkó mò [pé John ɕe German_F nìkan lẹ̀ẹ̀mejì].
teacher know COMP John do German only twice
- i. ‘The teacher knows that John only took *German* twice.’ (and knows that John took French once) (know>only)
ii. ‘The teacher only knows that John took *German* twice.’ (but doesn’t know that John took French twice as well). (only>know)

- b. Olùkọ́ (kàn) mò [pé Adé_F nìkan ʃe Faransé]. (... (c))
 teacher only know COMP Ade only do French
 ‘The teacher only know that Ade took French.’ (only > know)
- c. ... Olùkọ́ kò mò bóyá àwọn akẹ̀kọ̀ yòókù ʃe Faransé.
 teacher NEG know whether PL student other take French
 ‘The teacher doesn’t know whether other students took French.’

3.2 Island effects

Such scopal flexibility of adfocal particles, however, is constrained by syntactic locality. Specifically, the wide scope readings are unavailable across island boundaries. Let us consider the scenario in (24). With narrow scope (*punish*>*only*), the teacher only punished Group C, which is not a responsible move since Group A also fed poisonous chocolate to dogs. With wide scope (*only*>*punish*), the teacher is responsible for punishing both Group A and C.

- (24) “Chocolate feeding” Scenario [GpA: dog & rat | GpB: rat | GpC: dog]
 Student group A fed both dogs and rats chocolates, B fed only rats chocolates, and C fed only dogs chocolates. Since dogs cannot eat chocolates whereas rats can, both groups A and C should be punished by the teacher.
- a. *Wide scope (only*>*punish*):
 The teacher only punished [students [who gave DOGs chocolates]]
- b. *Narrow scope (punish*>*only*):
 #The teacher punished [students [who only gave DOGs chocolates]]

Now, consider (25) with the adfocal *only* in a complex NP island (CNPI) of a relative clause. The only reading is the narrow scope one, where the teacher did not punish Group A. In other words, *only* cannot take wide scope across a CNPI.

- (25) #The teacher punishes [students [who gave **only** DOGs chocolates]]
 (i.e., Only Group A is punished) (punish>only)

Turning to Yorùbá, *nìkan* also cannot take wide scope across islands. As can be seen in (26), when *nìkan* is embedded in a CNPI, only the narrow scope reading is available, and *kàn* can be optionally pronounced in the island to indicate the scope. To express the wide scope reading, *kàn* must be placed in the matrix clause *without* *nìkan* in the CNPI.

(26) Absence of wide scope across complex NP islands

- a. # Olùkò náà fi iyà jẹ́ [DP àwọn akẹ̀kọ̀ọ́ [CP tí wọn (**kàn**)
teacher the use suffer beat PL student COMP 3PL only
fún ajá_f **nìkan** ní chocolate]].
give dog only SEC chocolate
'The teacher punished students who only gave dogs chocolates.'
(i.e., Only Group C is published) (punish>only)
- b. Olùkò náà **kàn** fi iyà jẹ́ [DP àwọn akẹ̀kọ̀ọ́ [CP tí wọn
teacher the only use suffer beat PL student COMP 3PL
fún ajá_f (#**nìkan**) ní chocolate]].
give dog only SEC chocolate
'The teacher only punished students who gave dogs chocolates.'
(i.e., Group A and C are published) (punish>only)

Other islands also restrict the scope. In (27), *nìkan* is in an adjunct island of conditional clauses, and only the narrow scope reading is available. Again, the wide scope reading is achieved by placing *kàn* in the matrix clause.

(27) Absence of wide scope across adjunct islands

- a. Olùkò náà mò [pé [adjunct bí John bá (**kàn**) ẹ́ German_f
teacher the know COMP if John if only do German
nìkan], inú olùkò German yóò dùn].
only stomach teacher German will sweet
'The teacher knows that if John only took German, the German teacher
would be happy.' (And knows that if John also took French, the Ger-
man teacher will not be happy) (know>only)
- b. Olùkò náà **kàn** mò [pé [adjunct bí John bá ẹ́ German_f
teacher the only know COMP if John if do German
(#**nìkan**)], inú olùkò German yóò dùn].
only stomach teacher German will sweet
'The teacher only knows that if John took German, the German teacher
will be happy.' (But doesn't know about French) (only>know)

Table 1 gives a summary of the syntactic and semantic properties of *kàn* and *nìkan*.

¹²Except DP-internal focus cases due to an independent ban of DP-internal positions.

Table 1: The syntactic/semantic properties of Yorùbá exclusive particles

	<i>Nìkan</i>	<i>Kà̀n</i>
Particle types	Adfocal	Preverbal
Syntactic position	Immediately follows F	In-between Subj and V
AwF (in-situ)	Adjacent to F ¹²	At a distance, c-command F
AwF (ex-situ)	Must move together	Associate with moved F without c-commanding it
Embedded in CPs	Wide/narrow scope	Narrow scope
Embedded in islands	Narrow scope	Narrow scope

4 The proposal

4.1 The quantifier-particle approach

In this section, we propose the *quantifier-particle approach* to exclusive focus particles. We argue that this Q-approach captures the Yorùbá pattern better than the operator-particle approach, the latter of which makes empirical predictions that are not borne out in Yorùbá.

The components of the Q-approach are given in (28):

- (28) The quantifier-particle approach
- Semantic import*: *Nìkan* is an exclusive quantifier whereas *kà̀n* is a scope-marking particle without exclusive interpretation.
 - Syntactic dependency*: DP-*nìkan* moves to FP headed by *kà̀n* for scope.

We propose it is *nìkan*, but not *kà̀n*, that carries the exclusive semantics. *Nìkan* is a two-place quantifier with the semantics in (29) (after Rooth 1985):¹³

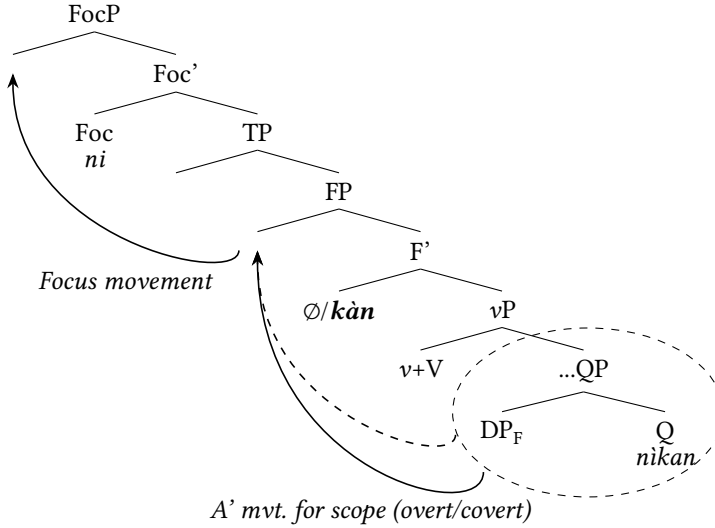
$$(29) \llbracket nìkan \rrbracket = \lambda x. \lambda P. \forall y [P(y) \rightarrow y = x]$$

Thus, there is no form-meaning mismatch in doubling cases: only one particle contributes to exclusivity. We also suggest that there is a null counterpart of *nìkan*, QU_{EXCL} , on par with the null exclusive operator in the OP-approach. When only *kà̀n* is present, the exclusivity comes from QU_{EXCL} .

¹³For simplicity, we did not build in the sensitivity to DP-internal focus (e.g., (7)) here. We assume that those cases are achieved by implicit domain restrictions (e.g., $y \in D_e^c$, where c is a relevant context), independently required for quantifiers (e.g., Stanley & Gendler Szabó 2000).

Syntactically, *nikan*, with the focus associate, moves to a projection headed by *kàn* for scope (i.e., narrow vs. wide), labeled as FP for expository purposes. The function of *kàn* is thus to indicate where *nikan* is interpreted (i.e., scope-marking). The movement is generally covert, but becomes overt when the focus marker *ni* is present, as illustrated below:

(30) Movement in exclusive doubling in Yorùbá



It is important to note that we do not assume the covert movement to be Quantifier-Raising (QR). QR is generally clause-bounded, which is inconsistent with the fact that *nikan* may take wide scope across CP boundaries. We assume that it is an A'-movement with Pronounce Lower Copy (Bošković & Nunes 2007), similar to covert *wh*-movement in *wh*-in-situ languages like Coptic Egyptian (Reintges 2007) or Mongolian (Fong 2019). We suggest that the higher copy fails to be pronounced due to an independent PF constraint that only particles may occur between the subject and the verb, which is where SpecFP is located. When the focus is further moved up to, for instance, SpecFocP in the presence of *ni* (after Awóbùlúyì 1978; Ilorì 2010; Aremu 2024),¹⁴ the highest copy before the subject is pronounced.

¹⁴We assume the monoclausal focus movement analysis of *ni* in this paper. For a biclausal cleft analysis, see Bisang & Sonaiya (2000); Adesola (2005); Jones (2006).

- (31) a. Covert movement: pronounce the lowest copy
 [TP Subj [FP ~~DP nikan~~ ... [VP <DP-nikan> ...
 b. Overt focus movement: pronounce the highest copy
 [FocP <DP-nikan> ... [TP Subj [FP ~~DP nikan~~ ... [VP ~~DP nikan~~ ...

With the ingredients in place, we can now derive the AwF and scopal properties of *kàn* and *nikan*. The scopal ambiguities are captured by the movement of *nikan*, as given in (32):

- (32) a. Covert movement to embedded FP for narrow scope
 [CP1 ... [VP V [CP2 [FP $\xrightarrow{\uparrow}$ [F' *kàn* ... [QP DP_F-*nikan*]]]]]]
 b. Covert movement to matrix FP for wide scope
 [CP1 ... [FP $\xrightarrow{\uparrow}$ [F' *kàn* ... [VP V [CP2 ... [QP DP_F-*nikan*]]]]]]

When it moves to the embedded FP, it is interpreted under the matrix verb, yielding narrow scope. When it moves to the matrix FP, it acquires wide scope over the matrix verb. Since *kàn* merely marks where *nikan* is interpreted, it cannot have such scopal ambiguities. Moreover, since movement is blocked across islands, *nikan* cannot move to matrix FP, and hence the absence of wide scope readings, as illustrated in (33).

- (33) Covert movement blocked by islands
 *[CP1 ... [FP $\xrightarrow{\uparrow}$ [F' *kàn* ... [VP V [islands ... [QP DP_F-*nikan*]]]]]]]
 X

An important question, raised by both anonymous reviewers, is why cases with only *kàn* are free from island effects, as we have seen in (26b)–(27b), the latter of which is reproduced below. Assuming that *kàn* always requires a covert *nikan* (Q_{EXCL}), an adjunct island would be violated if Q_{EXCL} moved from within it to the matrix clause above *mò* ‘know’.

- (34) Olùkò náà *kàn* mò [pé [adjunct bí John bá ɕe Germanɿ (#*nikan*)],
 teacher the only know COMP if John if do German only
 inú olùkò German yòò dùn].
 stomach teacher German will sweet
 ‘The teacher only knows that if John takes German, the German teacher
 will be happy.’ (But doesn’t know about French) (only>know)

We suggest that there is no covert movement from the island, but it is the whole complement clause with the island that moves, resembling island pied-piping in Japanese covert *wh*-movement (Nishigauchi 1990). Precisely, we propose that QU_{EXCL} attaches to the complement clause as in (35a). This is possible since *nikan* may attach to a CP (as in (10a)) and may associate with elements within its syntactic sister (e.g., DP-internal focus in (7)). Crucial evidence comes from the fact that the QU_{EXCL} in (35a) can in fact be spelt out as *nikan* and undergoes overt focus movement with the whole complement clause in (35b), with the focus association with *German* in the adjunct island.

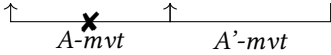
- (35) a. $[FP \text{ } \overset{\uparrow}{\text{...}} [VP \text{ } m\grave{o} \text{ } [QP [CP [\text{adjunct ...} \textit{German}_F \text{...}] \text{...}] -QU_{EXCL}]]]$
- b. $[CP \text{ pé } [\text{adjunct } b\acute{i} \text{ John } b\acute{a} \text{ } \acute{s}e \text{ } \textit{German}_F], \text{ inú } olùk\acute{o} \text{ German } \text{COMP} \text{ if John if do German } \text{stomach teacher German } y\acute{o}d\acute{o} \text{ dùn}] \text{ nikan } ni \text{ Olùk\acute{o} } n\acute{a}\acute{a} \text{ (k\acute{a}n) } m\grave{o} \text{ } \text{---}.$
 will sweet only FOC teacher the only know
 Lit.: ‘It is only that [if John takes *German*, the German teacher will be happy] that the teacher knows.’ (But the teacher doesn’t know what would happen if John took French.) (only>know)

The peculiar AwF of *kàn* can also be derived. Recall that subject focus with *kàn* is possible in the *ex-situ* but not *in-situ* cases. This can be explained by the nature of the movement chain. Under the assumption that movement to SpecTP is A-movement, *in-situ* subject focus involves movement from SpecvP to SpecFP (A’), then to SpecTP (A), which forms an Improper A-A’-A chain (Chomsky 1973), as in (36a). In contrast, the *ex-situ* focus movement does not move through SpecTP. As given in (36b), it moves directly from SpecFP to SpecFocP without landing on SpecTP, as evidenced by the resumptive/expletive pronoun *ó* in the subject position (for EPP requirements, see Adesola 2010).¹⁵ Since both steps are A’-movement, the derivation is licit and the AwF pattern is captured. Strictly speaking, *kàn* is simply a scope-marking particle and does not establish its own AwF, as will be discussed in the next sub-section.

¹⁵ Aremu (2024) argues that subject *ni*-focus is base-generated. However, the *ex-situ* subject focus may be reconstructed for reflexive binding as in (i), supporting a movement approach.

(i) $[iw\acute{e} \text{ n\acute{i}p\acute{a} \text{ are } r\acute{e}_i] \text{ ni } Ad\acute{e}_i \text{ s\acute{o} } p\acute{e} \text{ } \acute{o} \text{ } d\acute{a}r\acute{a}$
 book about body self FOC Ade say COMP 3SG good
 ‘It is the book about himself_i that Ade_i said is good.’

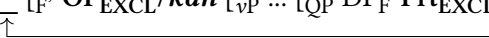
- (36) a. In-situ subject focus with *kàn*: Improper Movement

$$*[\text{TP} [\text{QP} \text{Subj}_F\text{-}\textit{nikan}/\text{Qu}_{\text{EXCL}}] [\text{FP} \text{ } \text{ } [\text{F}' \textit{kàn} [\text{vP} \text{ } \text{ } [\text{v}' \textit{v VP}]]]]]]$$

- b. Ex-situ subject focus with *kàn*

$$[\text{FocP} [\text{QP} \text{Subj}_F\text{-}\textit{nikan}/\text{Qu}_{\text{EXCL}}] \textit{ni} [\text{TP} \textit{ó} \text{'3SG'} [\text{FP} \text{ } \text{ } [\text{F}' \textit{kàn} [\text{vP} \text{ } \text{ } [\text{v}' \textit{v VP}]]]]]]]]$$


4.2 Against an operator-particle approach

In the following, we argue that the OP-approach proposed for other languages (Lee 2005; Quek & Hirsch 2017; Sun 2021; Yip 2025; Aremu 2025, *i.a.*) cannot be extended to Yorùbá. Under the OP-approach, *kàn* is the exclusive operator and *nikan* is a “concord” particle that must (covertly) move to FP, as schematized in (37). This analysis captures the scopal ambiguities in §3 equally well with the proposed Q-approach, by resorting to relative positions of the (c)overt operator (see, e.g., Bassi et al. 2022).

- (37) An operator-particle analysis for Yorùbá, ver.1 (*to be rejected*)
- a. $\llbracket \textit{kàn} \rrbracket (ALT) = \lambda p \lambda w : p(w). \forall q [(q \in ALT \wedge q(w)) \rightarrow p \subseteq q]$
- b.
$$[\text{FP} \text{ } \text{ } [\text{F}' \text{OP}_{\text{EXCL}}/\textit{kàn} [\text{vP} \dots [\text{QP} \text{DP}_F\text{-}\text{Prt}_{\text{EXCL}}/\textit{nikan}]]]]]$$


We argue against such an OP-approach with the following four arguments:

- (38) a. Backward association with focus
 b. Multiple associations with focus
 c. Scopal interaction with negation
 d. Wide scope under ellipsis

The first argument comes from the ex-situ AwF of *kàn*. As we have already seen in §2.2, *kàn* may associate “backwards” with the focus that is moved out of its c-commanding domain. Backward AwF, however, is cross-linguistically rare, if not impossible (Jackendoff 1972; Tancredi 1990; Beaver & Clark 2008; Erlewine 2014, but see Bayer 2018:249-250 for potential exceptions in German). The backward AwF is unexpected under the OP-approach, but it is the natural consequence of the Q-approach where *kàn* is a scope-marking particle that has no AwF.

The second argument concerns whether multiple AwFs are possible, as adopted from Yip (2024; 2025) for Cantonese. If *kàn* is an operator, we expect it to establish focus association independent of *nikan*. Similar configurations are possible in English. In (39), the adverbial *only* associates with the object whereas the adfocal *only* associates with the subject, giving rise to a multiple ‘only’ reading (see Horn 1969 for more examples).

- (39) **Only** JOHN_{F1} **only** reads [ENGLISH books]_{F2}. (multi-‘only’ reading)
 ‘John is the only person who only reads English books.’

In Yorùbá, however, multiple AwFs cannot be achieved by (clausemate) *kàn-nikan* pairs. Let us first consider a multi-‘only’ reading where the first ‘only’ associates with the subject focus and the second ‘only’ associates with the object focus. This is possible with two *nikan*, as in (40a). In contrast, without the second *nikan* in (40b), a *kàn-nikan* pair fails to deliver the multi-‘only’ reading and hence is not felicitous response to the question in the context. The only available AwF is with the subject attached by *nikan*, giving a doubled reading. *Kàn* cannot associate otherwise with the object to give a multi-‘only’ reading, even though it is within its scope. This pattern is unexpected if *kàn* is the operator. The OP-approach only predicts that adfocal particles may disambiguate between different AwF possibilities in single-focus cases. In multiple-focus cases, however, multiple operators should in principle be available to establish more than one AwF to derive cases like (39). Under the Q-approach, on the other hand, such a pattern is a natural consequence of *nikan* being the quantifier.

- (40) [Context: Who only reads English books?]
- a. John_{F1} **nikan** ni ó máa-ń ka [àwọn iwé Gẹ̀ẹ̀sì]_{F2} **nikan**
 John only FOC 3SG HAB-PROG read PL book English only
 ‘John is the only person who only reads English books.’ (and other people read both En. books and Fr. books) (multi-‘only’ reading)
- b. #John_{F1} **nikan** ni ó **kàn** máa-ń ka [àwọn iwé Gẹ̀ẹ̀sì]_(F2)
 John only FOC 3SG only HAB-PROG read PL book English
 #‘John is the only person who just reads English books (e.g., for fun).’
 (other people does not read English books) (Subj. focus)
 NOT: ‘John is the only person who only reads English books.’ (Other people read both En.-books and Fr.-books) (*multi-‘only’ reading)

The third argument is about scopal interaction with negation. Consider (41a)-(41b). The negation takes wide scope over ‘only’ when *kì-i* ‘not (habitual)’

precedes the *ex-situ* focus, and narrow scope under ‘only’ when *kò* ‘not’ follows the focus, where *nikan* may or may not be pronounced. In both cases, however, the negation is higher than *kàn*. If *kàn* were really an operator, both (41a)-(41b) should have had a wide scope negation reading, which is not the case. In contrast, the Q-approach captures that it is the position of the (c)overt quantifier *nikan* that determines the scope.

- (41) a. *kì-í* *şe* German_F (*nikan*) *ni* John *kàn* *şe* __
 NEG do German only FOC John only do
 ‘It is not only German that John takes (but also French).’ (i.e., John takes German and French) (NEG>only)
- b. German (*nikan*) *ni* John *kò* *kàn* *şe* __
 German only FOC John NEG only do
 ‘It is only German that John just didn’t take.’ (i.e., John didn’t take German—he took French and Latin) (only>NEG)

It is now clear from the above three cases that *kàn* is not an exclusive operator. However, there is an alternative implementation of the OP-approach, where the operator is always null and both *kàn* and *nikan* are “concord” particles, as illustrated in (42).

- (42) An operator-particle analysis for Yorùbá, ver.2 (*to be rejected*)
- [_{ExclP} [_{Excl'} OP_{EXCL} [_{FP} *kàn* [_{VP} ... [_{QP} DP_F-Prt_{EXCL}/*nikan*]]]]]
-

We present an argument from VP ellipsis *against* (42). As a cross-linguistically robust generalization, exclusive operators cannot associate with elided materials (English: Beaver & Clark 2008:§7; Bassi et al. 2022; Cantonese: Cheung 2009:213; Kasem: Aremu 2025; cf. Tancredi 1990), as shown by the VP ellipsis in (43).¹⁶

- (43) a. Kim only SALUTES because Sandy only SALUTES.
 b. *Kim only SALUTES because Sandy only does ~~SALUTES~~.
 (Beaver & Clark 2008:177)

¹⁶ Unless the operator is included in the elided site. This constraint is formulated as (i) by Bassi et al. (2022).

(i) Beaver & Clark’s Constraint (Bassi et al. 2022:817, cf. Beaver & Clark 2008)
Only and its associated Foc cannot be separated by a node targeted for ellipsis.

Bassi et al. (2022) argue that English adfocal *only* is not a quantifier, and it merely signals the presence of a null operator (see Aremu 2025 for Kasem). In (44a), *only* may take scope over or under *may*. The scopal ambiguity, however, disappears with ellipsis in (44b). *Only* only has narrow scope under *may* (i.e., Jill is allowed to not bring anything other than wine). Bassi et al. (2022) propose that the lack of wide scope readings is due to the illicit association with elided materials by a null operator above *may*, as in (44d). On the other hand, an operator lower than *may* can be included in the elided site (see footnote 16), enabling the narrow scope reading.

- (44) a. Jill may bring **only** WINE. (may>only, only>may)
 b. Jill may bring **only** WINE. Bill may, too. (may>only, *only>may)
 c. OK[Bill [may ~~EXCL [bring only WINE]~~]]]
 d. *[Bill [EXCL [may ~~bring only WINE]~~]]]
 (adapted from Bassi et al. 2022:816,818)

Turning to Yorùbá, *nìkan* similarly has scopal ambiguities with verbs like ‘permit’ in (45a). Strikingly, both wide and narrow scope are *retained* when *nìkan* and the focus are elided in (45b). The existence of the wide scope reading can be further confirmed by the felicitous continuation in (45c). This speaks against the presence of a null operator before ‘permit’.

- (45) a. Olùkó nàà gba John láàyè [láti ɕe German_F **nìkan**]. (...)
 teacher the permit John give.chance to do German only
 i. ‘The teacher allows John to take only German.’ (John can take French if he likes) (permit>only)
 ii. ‘The teacher only allows John to take German.’ (John cannot take French) (only>permit)
 b. ... Olùkó gba Mary nàà láàyè. (...)
 teacher permit Mary as.well give.chance
 i. ‘The teacher also allows Mary to take only German.’ (Mary can take French if he likes) (permit>only)
 ii. ‘The teacher also only allows Mary to take German.’ (Mary cannot take French) (only>permit)
 c. ... Fún idí èyí Mary kò lè ɕe Faransé.
 for reason this Mary NEG can do French
 ‘Therefore, Mary cannot take French.’

Note further that (D-)quantifiers may take wide scope under ellipsis (Sag 1976; Fox 2000; Bassi et al. 2022), patterning with *nikan*, as shown below:

- (46) a. A boy is standing on every building. (...) (every>a)
b. A girl is, too. (every>a)
(Bassi et al. 2022:820)

We therefore conclude *nikan* is a quantifier, and the null-operator alternative in (42) cannot be upheld.¹⁷

5 Concluding remarks

To conclude, this paper has argued for an alternative and novel view on exclusive doubling, namely, the quantifier-particle approach. We drew data from a pair of understudied exclusive focus particles ‘only’ from Yorùbá, preverbal *kàn* and adfocal *nikan*. We have demonstrated that *nikan* is the exclusive quantifier and *kàn* is a scope-marking particle where *nikan* with the focus covertly moves to. This view captures a number of patterns in doubling that are distinct from other languages, including backward association with focus, failure of multiple associations, unexpected scopal interaction with negation, and survival of wide scope readings under ellipsis. We suggest that the operator-particle approach cannot be upheld in Yorùbá despite the surface similarities with the adverbial-adfocal distinction in other languages (e.g., Quek & Hirsch 2017; Bassi et al. 2022; Sun 2021): there is no exclusive operator in Yorùbá, neither *kàn* nor a null one.

The findings implicate that languages vary in the source of exclusivity of focus particles: from an operator or a quantifier. Nevertheless, languages recruit a similar set of syntactic relations in exclusive doubling. Covert movement of adfocal particles is also found in other doubling languages (e.g., Vietnamese, Yip 2025). We would like to stress the importance of cross-linguistic studies in exclusive focus particles, and more work is needed to uncover the universals and variations in this domain.

¹⁷Recently, Aremu (2026) replies to this paper (our work was circulated in 2024), and argues for an operator-particle approach to Yorùbá. Due to space reasons, we are unable to respond to his counterarguments here, but we refer readers to Yip (2026) for a full rebuttal.

Abbreviations

1, 2, 3	first, second, third person, respectively
COMP	complementizer
FOC	focus marker
HAB	habitual aspect
NEG	negation
PL	plural
PFV	perfective aspect
PROG	progressive aspect
Q	question particle
SEC	secundative preposition
SG	singular

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